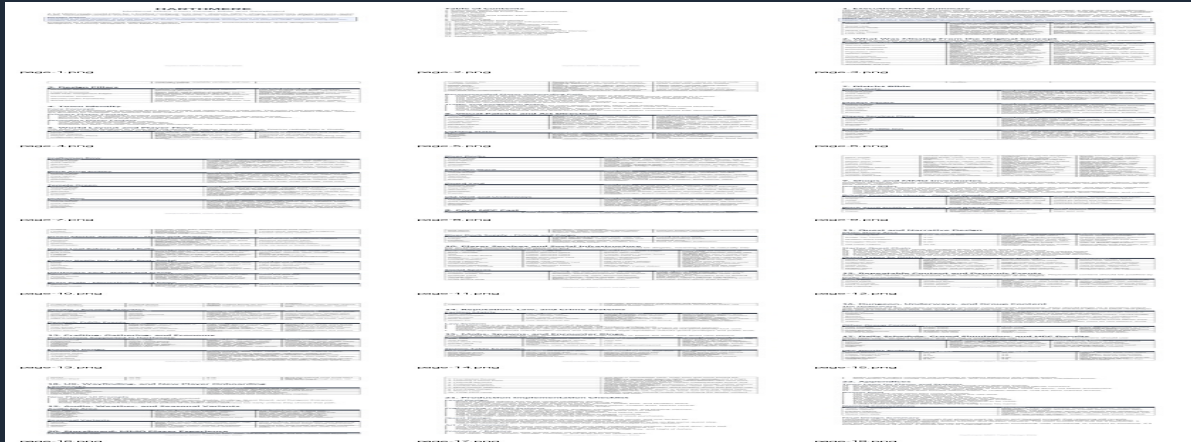




Harthmere

Expanded Medieval MMO Town

Design Bible

Worldbuilding • Art Direction • Economy • Quests • Vendors • Social Systems •
Production Checklist

Prepared as a complete, MMO-ready town package with finer aesthetic detail, exact art-direction guidance, player-service planning, and system-level design notes.

Design Goal: Take the original medieval town concept and push it into a production-ready MMO hub: readable, memorable, systemic, socially useful, and rich in visual identity.

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This edition pushes the finer details with exact palette notes, street-level aesthetics, signage rules, production checklists, gameplay-service mapping, and clearer formatting for teams building a real MMO town.

1. Executive Summary

Harthmere is a fortified medieval river town designed as a first major MMO settlement and a long-term social hub. It is not just a backdrop. It is a service node, quest hub, economy anchor, social gathering point, narrative engine, and visual identity marker for the wider game world.

The town should feel **warm but worn, practical but storied, and safe enough to return to but never fully without tension**. Players should read the town instantly: the gate says authority, the market says trade, the smithy says utility, the chapel says lore, the tavern says social comfort, and the docks and underways signal risk and hidden opportunity.

For MMO use, Harthmere must succeed at six things: orient new players, support repeat visits, provide clear service locations, deliver town-specific progression, host social friction and community rituals, and remain visually memorable even after hundreds of returns.

Design Need	How Harthmere Solves It	Player Result
Onboarding hub	Clear entry gate, readable market core, strong landmark network	Players learn the world without getting lost
Service settlement	Repair, bank, auction, mail, crafting, food, stables, rumors, bind point	Town remains useful at all levels
Social retention	Inn, event square, dueling edge, notice board, festival loop, tavern stage	Players gather instead of only passing through
Economic depth	Profession inputs, gold sinks, rotating stock, local recipes, smuggling hooks	Town supports a living economy
Narrative replay	Reputation branches, dailies, district factions, underways, dynamic events	Town stays relevant after the main story
Memorable identity	Strong palette, district-specific materials, fog, bells, river lighting	Town becomes iconic

2. What Was Missing and What Was Added for the MMO Version

The original town bible already had strong worldbuilding, but an MMO town needs additional systems and finer detail. The chart below shows what was added or pushed further in this expanded version.

Category	Original Limitation	Expanded MMO Detail Added
Art direction	Broad mood and colors	Exact palettes, materials, trim rules, lighting states, signage language, seasonal swaps
Player flow	Town described narratively	Service loops, entry route, sightlines, onboarding route, fast-travel and recall logic
MMO services	Implicit only	Bank, auction house, storage, trainers, repair, mail, guild board, event board, social spaces
Vendor design	Flavor inventory	Common, limited, reputation, recipe, illegal, cosmetic, and rotating stock categories
Crafting	Shop flavor only	Profession chain, node sourcing, commissions, gold sinks, storage logic, recipe unlocks
Economy	Town trade implied	Currency sinks, listing fees, repair pressure, consumable loops, local specialty goods
Quests and repeatables	Story hooks present	Starter quests, dailies, weeklies, festival events, branching reputation arcs

Category	Original Limitation	Expanded MMO Detail Added
NPC density	Named NPCs only	Ambient population budgets, schedules, crowd logic, event-time boosts
Social design	Tavern and market implied	Roleplay zones, guild use cases, dueling edge, music stage, wedding/festival utility
Technical readability	Aesthetic description	Interactivity color coding, silhouette rules, landmark visibility, accessibility guidance
Production use	Writer's journal tone	Asset checklist, props list, VFX list, audio list, implementation notes

3. Design Pillars

Pillar	Meaning	Concrete Rules
Readable at a glance	Players should understand district purpose in seconds	Strong landmarks, visible service signage, unique rooflines, reliable street hierarchy
Useful every return	Town must remain practical past the leveling phase	Service clustering, repeatable vendors, long-term reputation, festivals, auction house and storage
Rich but grounded	Feels medieval and lived-in, not theme-park fake	Mud, smoke, clutter, class contrast, believable goods, layered social tension
Social by design	Encourage player congregation	Inn hearth, stage, plaza seating, guild board, event loops, dock gatherings
Narratively layered	Every district tells a social and historical story	Visible wealth divide, ruins, flood markers, bell mystery, old stones, rumors
Systemically generous	Many loops share the same spaces	Crafting, trade, quests, roleplay, travel, gathering hand-ins, festivals all intersect

4. Core Identity, Tone, and Town Snapshot

Town role: Starter/early-mid hub with long-tail relevance.

Population fantasy: A town of around 1,200 within the walls, plus outer farms and river traffic.

Tone: Hearth-warm, politically tense, slightly dangerous after dark.

Primary visual themes: river stone, weathered oak, patched cloth, smoke, lantern glow, wet docks, old bridge masonry, and blue-gray chapel calm.

Emotional promise: Coming home after danger should feel real here.

- **First impression:** a muddy approach road, the stone gate, banners, bridge silhouette, and chimney smoke.
- **Core center:** the market square is the compass point and social anchor.
- **Upper power:** the Noble Rise visually watches the rest of town.
- **Lower danger:** the Mudden Ward and docks hold risk, secrets, and underclass stories.
- **Mystery layer:** the old well, buried bell, and underways give depth beneath the practical town surface.

5. Master Art Direction: Color, Materials, Lighting, and Aesthetics

This section pushes the finer visual details so the town reads consistently across concept art, environment art, lighting, VFX, UI maps, and level design.

5.1 Master Palette

Visual Family	Primary Colors	Use Case	Notes
Stone/fortification	#6E7278, #8B8F94, #B7B9B6	Walls, bridge, chapel foundations	Cool grays with moss staining; avoid clean modern stone
Timber/work materials	#4B3427, #6B4B36, #8B6646	Frames, carts, docks, doors	Grain should be visible; age darkens lower halves
Warm market accents	#C08A37, #93403A, #6C8272	Awnings, stalls, produce, cloth	Colorful but faded, never carnival-saturated
Faith and calm	#DEE3E5, #778593, #E7C772	Chapel, records, candles, ritual items	Soft blue-gray and candle gold
Poverty and soot	#5D5149, #85756A, #A5907C	Mudden Ward, smoke, patched cloth	Muted and low-value, but punctuated by laundry cloth
Water and night	#3A5365, #27404D, #AABBC5	River, dock reflections, fog, moonlight	Cool, reflective, contrast against warm windows

5.2 Architectural Grammar

- **Lower walls:** rough stone or limewashed masonry up to waist or chest height in practical districts; full stone in official buildings.
- **Upper stories:** dark timber frames with plaster infill; subtle leaning over streets in older zones.
- **Roofs:** thatch for poor homes and barns, red-brown clay tile for prosperous shops, blue-gray slate for chapel and elite buildings.
- **Chimneys:** short and frequent; smoke must be visible in cool weather.
- **Doors:** heavy oak with forged strap hinges; interactable doors should be slightly cleaner and framed with stronger silhouette contrast.
- **Windows:** shutters everywhere; leaded glass is limited to wealthy or sacred buildings.
- **Street profile:** clean center routes in main market arteries, side gutters, muddier shoulders, and occasional plank bridges over wet spots.

5.3 Lighting Rules

Time / Weather	Look	Gameplay / Mood Use
Dawn	Gold haze, long shadows, smoke rising, bridge mist	Best arrival mood; calm onboarding window
Midday	Neutral sun, readable signage, strong cloth colors	Highest clarity for browsing services
Evening	Amber windows, cool blue shadows, reflective river	Ideal for social play and tavern density
Night	Lantern pools, black alleys, moonlit stone	Mystery, stealth quests, docks danger
Rain	Darkened timber, bright puddle reflections, lowered saturation	Makes town feel tactile and lived-in
Fog	Silhouette-heavy, reduced long sightlines, glowing chapel windows	Great for atmosphere events and lore quests

5.4 Signage and Visual Communication

- Use **icon-first** shop signs for readability: anvil, kettle, loaf, mortar, scale, boot, fishhook, lantern, quill.
- Interactive service buildings should have slightly stronger trim or banner contrast than non-interactive homes.

- Quest-critical interiors should feature **one unique prop cluster** visible from the entrance: a buried bell fragment, a ledger wall, an oversized forge rack, a blue-ribbon shrine, etc.
- Avoid modern over-clean signage. Paint should chip, wood should split, and icons should feel hand-made.
- Use banners and ground clutter to reinforce district function: grain sacks in market, coils of rope at docks, shoe forms at leatherworker, herb bundles at apothecary.

6. MMO Layout, District Roles, and Player Flow

The town must support both narrative realism and efficient MMO usability. The ideal player route on first entry is: **North Gate → Market Square → Provisioner / Inn / Notice Board → Craftsman Row → Chapel → Choice of storyline branch.**

District	Primary MMO Role	Secondary Role	Key Service Density
North Gate	Arrival, validation, first security beat	Travel warnings, bounty returns	Low
Market Square	Commerce and social center	Public events, dailies, notice board	Very High
Craftsman Row	Repair and profession cluster	Recipe acquisition	High
Copper Kettle / Player Services Plaza	Inn, bind, rumors, rest	Roleplay, community, bard activity	Very High
Temple Green	Lore and healing hub	Records, rituals, charity, resurrection flavor	Medium
Noble Rise	Political story branch	Law, bureaucracy, permits	Medium
River Docks	Travel, fishing, smuggling, cargo quests	Risk content gateway	Medium
Mudden Ward	Stealth, underclass stories, tunnel access	Informal trade	Low
Old Well / Underways	Dungeon-like mystery layer	Group content gateway	Specialized

6.1 Service Placement Rules

- The player should never need to cross the full town just to repair, buy basics, set bind, or use storage.
- Starter services should cluster within 45–60 seconds of gate arrival.
- Higher-value and more specialized services can live on side streets if their signage is strong and the route is memorable.
- At least three anchor landmarks should be visible from the central square: the reeve's bannered hall above, the chapel lantern window, and the Copper Kettle sign.
- The town should support both keyboard/mouse MMO navigation and controller-friendly route clarity.

7. District Bible (Detailed)

Each district below includes finer aesthetic and systems guidance.

7.1 North Gate

Category	Direction
Role	Arrival, security gate, first impression, travel threshold.
Palette	Stone gray #6F7378, oak brown #4C3628, banner red #7D2B2A, road mud #7B6858.

Category	Direction
Materials	Heavy stone towers, iron-banded doors, weathered timber walkway, patched road ruts.
Props and dressing	Toll desk, notice board, hitching rails, wagon queue, guard brazier, stacked pikes.
Typical people	Gate guards, toll clerk, peddlers, farmers, caravan hands, a few beggar children.
Mood goal	Authoritative but not hostile; players should feel they are entering a protected place.
Gameplay use	Intro dialogue, bounty turn-ins, local travel tips, anti-smuggling checks, caravan escort hookups.
Audio	Chains, hoofbeats, cart creaks, guards calling, distant town bustle.
VFX / ambience	Breath smoke in winter, brazier sparks, drifting dust, crows on battlements.
Signage language	Bridge-and-sun crest, guard tabards, painted toll plank, hanging warning boards.

7.2 Market Square

Category	Direction
Role	Main commerce and social plaza; the heart of Harthmere.
Palette	Ochre #C18A3F, burgundy #8B3B34, faded teal #607B7E, vegetable green #6C7F48, cobble gray #A8A19A.
Materials	Wide cobbles, canvas stall roofs, carved fountain stone, timber carts.
Props and dressing	Produce piles, scales, chickens, wicker baskets, public stocks, posting board, benches.
Typical people	Food sellers, traders, clerks, children, gossipers, adventurers, performers.
Mood goal	Lively, noisy, crowded, communal; this is where players naturally idle.
Gameplay use	Auction access nearby, daily quests, event stage overflow, public speeches, festival center, group forming.
Audio	Vendors shouting, fountain splash, livestock, laughter, coin clinks.
VFX / ambience	Dust in sunlight, cooking smoke, banner flutter, evening lantern strings on event nights.
Signage language	Painted icons and hanging cloths; each major vendor gets a stronger color zone.

7.3 Player Services Plaza / Copper Kettle Cluster

Category	Direction
Role	Rest and utility hub wrapped around the inn.
Palette	Ale gold #C7A252, hearth orange #A85B2B, dark timber #3D2C22, plaster cream #E5D9C7.
Materials	Timber inn shell, broad hearth, iron lanterns, polished common-room surfaces.
Props and dressing	Kegs, benches, card tables, bard corner, room key board, travel chest, stable lane.
Typical people	Innkeeper, cooks, travelers, roleplayers, bards, mail runner, room attendant.
Mood goal	Comfort, relief, conversation, and useful downtime.
Gameplay use	Bind point, rest XP flavor, rumor purchases, social contracts, room rentals, guild meetups.
Audio	Mugs, fiddle, fire crackle, low conversation, stable snorts.
VFX / ambience	Fire sparks, pipe smoke, candle flicker, warm window glow visible at night.
Signage language	Large copper kettle sign, lantern cluster, chalkboard of room rates and performances.

7.4 Craftsman Row

Category	Direction
Role	Production district for practical goods, repairs, and profession identity.
Palette	Soot black #2F2D2B, forge orange #C96A22, leather brown #6C4C33, sawdust tan #C5A16F.
Materials	Stone lower walls, timber workshops, open sheds, forge mouths, stacked lumber.
Props and dressing	Anvils, barrels, hide racks, wheel frames, worktables, quenching tubs, scrap piles.
Typical people	Smiths, coopers, weavers, apprentices, carpenters, wheelwrights, leatherworkers.
Mood goal	Industrious, hot, useful, a little dangerous.
Gameplay use	Repair, profession trainers, work orders, recipe unlocks, commission hand-ins.
Audio	Hammering, sawing, leather stretching, bellows, potter wheel scrape.
VFX / ambience	Forge sparks, steam, drifting sawdust, kiln heat shimmer.
Signage language	Bold icon plaques; each shop has a signature prop silhouette visible from the street.

7.5 Temple Green and the Chapel of Saint Verena

Category	Direction
Role	Lore, healing, memorial, and ritual district.
Palette	Ivory #E2E5E3, slate blue #788796, candle gold #E5C67A, grass green #7C9470.
Materials	Pale stone chapel, slate roof, tidy garden walls, clean paths.
Props and dressing	Candles, records, shrine alcoves, benches, herb planters, memorial ribbons.
Typical people	Priests, supplicants, scribes, widows, choir children, pilgrims.
Mood goal	Peaceful and solemn, with a faint undertone of mystery.
Gameplay use	Healing flavor, resurrection lore, records access, confession-style quest delivery, holy reputation.
Audio	Soft bells, prayer murmurs, crows, cloth rustle.
VFX / ambience	Candle flicker, incense haze, colored light through glass, wind in grass.
Signage language	Lantern iconography, carved saint motifs, blue-ribbon memorial markers.

7.6 Noble Rise

Category	Direction
Role	Political and administrative district; visible seat of power.
Palette	Whitewash #E8E6E0, dark green #536652, banner red #7D2328, brass #AF8C45.
Materials	Cleaner stone paving, walled gardens, leaded glass, trimmed hedges.
Props and dressing	Ledger desks, guards, seal banners, polished doors, rose trellises.
Typical people	Reeve, clerks, household servants, tax men, visiting merchants.
Mood goal	Controlled, elevated, observant; social distance is part of the look.
Gameplay use	Political quests, legal permissions, debt intrigue, town-law progression.
Audio	Bootsteps on cleaner stone, muted conversation, pages turning, birds.
VFX / ambience	None heavy; this district should feel calmer and slightly curated.
Signage language	Sharper heraldic insignia and cleaner paint than the rest of town.

7.7 River Docks

Category	Direction
Role	Trade waterline, travel, fishing, cargo, danger, and smuggling.
Palette	Wet timber #5A4638, rope tan #AD936F, river blue #3C5567, algae green #617564.
Materials	Wooden piers, tarred posts, mooring rings, fish sheds, crane arms.
Props and dressing	Nets, barrels, crates, hooks, lantern posts, eel baskets, tar pots.
Typical people	Dockers, ferryman, fishmongers, bargemen, smugglers, inspectors.
Mood goal	Busy in day, suspicious at night, atmospheric in fog.
Gameplay use	Fishing, cargo deliveries, ferry travel, smuggling choices, dock events.
Audio	Water slap, gulls, rope creak, cargo thumps, dock calls.
VFX / ambience	Fog, dripping water, lantern reflections, rain sheen, gull flocks.
Signage language	Hooks, fish sigils, cargo markings, blue knot motifs for hidden smugglers.

7.8 Mudden Ward

Category	Direction
Role	Poor quarter and underclass social district.
Palette	Mud brown #6F5B4A, smoke gray #7F7770, patched cloth #A78E73, faded indigo #5A6274.
Materials	Leaning timber homes, patched roofs, dirt lanes, plank walkways.
Props and dressing	Laundry lines, broken stools, wash tubs, coal buckets, rat traps, stray cages.
Typical people	Laborers, widows, children, rat-catchers, informal traders, lookouts.
Mood goal	Tight, resilient, human, and vulnerable.
Gameplay use	Stealth routes, hidden vendors, tunnel leads, moral-choice quests, community aid dailies.
Audio	Babies, dogs, coughing, wash bucket splashes, neighbors arguing.
VFX / ambience	Thin smoke, puddle ripples, hanging cloth movement, occasional candle-in-window cues.
Signage language	Hand-painted, improvised, and inconsistent; authenticity matters more than polish.

7.9 Old Well and Underways

Category	Direction
Role	Mystery district and dungeon gateway.
Palette	Cold gray #60656D, moss green #556B5A, deep shadow #23272C, iron #50555B.
Materials	Cracked stone, barred wellhead, old drains, submerged brick, hidden chambers.
Props and dressing	Rusted grates, water channels, rope descents, old coins, ritual markings.
Typical people	Few visible townsfolk; mostly quest traffic, scavengers, secretive figures.
Mood goal	Ancient, damp, slightly unnerving.
Gameplay use	Dungeon access, lore hunts, hidden collectibles, group encounters, seasonal haunted event.
Audio	Drips, distant metallic ringing, rat scurry, low air hum.
VFX / ambience	Mist, water droplets, darkness pockets, echoing lantern halos.

Category	Direction
Signage language	Subtle and secretive; no obvious public signage, only rumor clues and coded markings.

8. Core NPC Cast, Daily Schedules, and Ambient Population

Named NPCs matter, but so does the crowd. A believable MMO town needs both anchor characters and ambient population logic.

NPC	Core MMO Function	Flavor / Aesthetic Notes	Quest or System Value
Sergeant Bram Holt	Gate authority, combat onboarding	Scarred jaw, red-black tabard, tired eyes	Bounties, gate incidents, moral-choice smuggling checks
Mara Thistle	Market guide and food vendor	Red headscarf, muddy boots, loud voice	Market dailies, price rumors, food economy
Elowen Pike	Innkeeper and social host	Rolled sleeves, copper key ring, no-nonsense stare	Bind point, tavern quests, rumor purchase
Master Osric Vale	Blacksmith trainer and repair	Burn scars, broad frame, forge-lit silhouette	Repair, weapon commissions, rebel-history chain
Father Aldren	Healer and lore anchor	Thin, pale, wax-stained fingers	Chapel story, blessings, crypt mystery
Nessa Crowe	Mudden Ward guide	Quick grin, patched cloak, rat spear	Stealth quests, underways access, rescue chains
Tovin Reed	Dockmaster and river contact	Missing fingers, fishbone charm, ledgers	Fishing, shipping, smuggling paths
Reeve Caldus Merrow	Political ruler	Fine cloak, gloves, studied charm	Permits, taxes, law, branching politics
Ysabet Fenlow	Apothecary / alchemy	Clouded eyes, herb stains, green shawl	Alchemy supply, remedy quests, suspicion plots
Edrik Vane	Moneylender / pawn	Perfumed, soft-handed, brass pin	Debt notes, storage, blackmail storylines
Courier Anwen	Mail and timed delivery	Satchel, short cloak, fast pace	Mail access, delivery dailies, parcel theft events
Auction Clerk Pell	Auction house / trade board	Precise clothes, ink-stained cuffs	Listing tutorials, trade tax loop

8.1 Ambient Population Budgets

Area	Quiet Hours	Peak Hours	Notes
Market Square	18–24 ambient NPCs	35–45 ambient NPCs	Add event-only clusters during festivals
Gate	8–12	15–18	Queue visuals matter; use carts, not only people
Craftsman Row	10–14	18–22	Apprentice movement sells production
Copper Kettle cluster	12–18	20–28	Night density should rise
Chapel Green	6–10	10–14	Keep calmer than square
Noble Rise	5–9	8–12	Sparse on purpose
Docks	10–16	16–24	Night swaps fewer workers for more suspicious silhouettes
Mudden Ward	8–12	12–18	Keep density in doorways and lanes, not open clustering

8.2 Daily Schedule Logic

- **Dawn:** bakers, fishermen, chapel bells, gate opening, smoke rising.
- **Morning:** market setup, craft workshops active, first tutorial foot traffic.
- **Midday:** maximum commerce, highest ambient chatter, best service clarity.
- **Evening:** tavern fills, market thins, quest hand-ins and social use climb.
- **Night:** fewer lawful NPCs outside, more watch patrols, docks and underways shift to higher-risk flavor.

9. Shops, Vendors, and MMO Inventories

Vendor inventory should be MMO-scaled rather than purely decorative. Every major shop should have a mix of **always available stock**, **limited stock**, **reputation rewards**, **profession recipes**, and occasionally **rotating curiosities**.

Vendor	Core Offer	Always Available	Long-Term MMO Value
Brindle Provision House	General goods	Bags, lanterns, rope, rations, chalk, waterskins	Utility purchases, starter tools, rotating travel stock
Black Anvil Smithy	Repair and weapon basics	Repair, durability restore, simple weapons, metal fittings	Crafting orders, reputation weapon skins, forged components
Green Mortar Apothecary	Herbs and alchemy	Bandages, salves, common herbs, vials	Potion crafting, antidote recipes, suspicion quests
Dawn Loaf Bakery	Food buffs	Bread, porridge, pastry, pies	Buff food progression, holiday baking content
Copper Kettle Inn	Food, rest, social services	Meals, rooms, bind/rest, rumors	Social contracts, event hosting, tavern cosmetics
Harthmere Yard	Stable and travel	Feed, tack, rental mount, local cart ride	Mount care, travel fees, cosmetic tack
Brass Scale	Loans, pawn, storage	Currency exchange, storage upgrade, appraisals	Debt storylines, pawned curios, legal witnessing

9.1 Inventory Structure Rules

- **Common:** practical items never gated behind reputation.
- **Limited:** better but non-essential items on timer restocks.
- **Reputation:** cosmetics, titles, recipes, special kits, and district-flavored variants.
- **Crafting:** profession tools, ingredients, and work-order consumables.
- **Illegal / hidden:** unlocked only by specific trust or story paths.
- **Gold sinks:** repair, storage expansion, auction fees, mount stabling, festival booths, legal paperwork, commissions.

9.2 Shop Detail Examples

Shop	Aesthetic Notes	Sample Limited / Rep Items	Why It Matters
Provision House	Dusty shelves, rope coils, map case, stacked packs	Waterproof map case, sealed lockbox, bridge toll voucher bundle	Makes a general store feel like a town utility node
Smithy	Coal smoke, sparks, horseshoe wall, quenching tub	Reinforced buckler, town-guard spear pattern, Osric rebel blade cosmetic	Lets repair and weapon identity live in one place

Shop	Aesthetic Notes	Sample Limited / Rep Items	Why It Matters
Apothecary	Dry herbs, amber jars, parchment labels, mortar stone	Flood-fever cure recipe, incense oil, quieting draught via hidden track	Creates both trustworthy and suspicious alchemy play
Bakery	Warm ovens, flour dust, hanging herbs, sweet steam	Festival seed cake, hearth bread recipe, baker apron cosmetic	Adds food progression and comfort identity
Inn	Copper kettle sign, bard nook, room keys, common tables	Locked private room rental, bard token, tavern regular title	Supports roleplay and social recurrence

10. Crafting, Gathering, Storage, and Economy Loops

Harthmere should feel like a real production town. The economy should be grounded in believable goods but tuned for MMO loops.

Profession	In-Town Support	Local Inputs / Hooks	Town Identity Contribution
Blacksmithing	Forge, repair, metal fittings	Iron scrap, nails, charcoal, hinges, blades	Harthmere feels practical and industrious
Leatherworking	Boots, belts, tack, satchels	Hides from hunters, buckles, dyes	Supports travel and mount fantasy
Carpentry / Woodworking	Handles, shields, furniture, crates	Lumber, pegs, resin, plans	Connects market, stables, docks, housing
Cooking	Bakery, inn kitchen, festival food	Flour, herbs, honey, fish, apples	Strong comfort loop and buff economy
Alchemy	Herbs, remedies, incense	River reeds, grave moss, willow bark, dreamcap	Ties world exploration into town crafting
Fishing	River and dock supply chain	Trout, eel, reeds, bait	Makes the river an economy feature
Tailoring	Cloaks, bags, banners, repairs	Wool, linen, dye, thread	Supports visual identity and cosmetics

10.1 Economy Design

System	Purpose	Town Expression
Vendor gold sinks	Remove currency from circulation	Repair bills, storage expansions, mount stabling, festival booth fees
Auction and listing fees	Trade friction and value control	Market square trade office / Auction Clerk Pell
Work orders	Give crafters repeatable relevance	Craftsman Row commission board
Consumable turnover	Keep food and potion markets alive	Bakery, inn, apothecary, fishing inputs
Local specialty recipes	Town-specific identity	Harthmere hearth bread, flood-fever cure, bridge-guard spear polish
Storage pressure	Encourage upgrading and logistics	Brass Scale vault lockers and bag purchases

10.2 Gathering Ring Around the Town

- **South farms:** barley, wheat, apples, flax, chickens, honey.
- **Riverbank:** reeds, willow bark, fish, clay pockets, river mint.
- **Hillside scrub:** rabbits, game birds, mushrooms, blackberries.
- **Old ruins / grave edges:** grave moss, rare flowers, ritual stones, bone fragments (quest use only).
- **Woodlot:** timber, resin, charcoal inputs, wolf threat routes.

11. Quests, Events, Reputation, and Story Hooks

Quest design should treat Harthmere as a town with both a **main arc** and a **recurring live loop**.

Quest Layer	Examples	Reward Style	Replay Value
Starter quest line	Gate entry, first market tasks, inn lodging, first rumor	XP, coin, starter kit, map literacy	One-time onboarding
District quest chains	Bell mystery, tax unrest, dock smuggling, underways, noble intrigue	Gear, reputation, story unlocks	Medium / branching
Daily quests	Market deliveries, fisher turn-ins, chapel charity, patrol help	Coin, crafting mats, local rep	High
Weekly content	Town fair contracts, bridge security sweep, faction bundles	Reputation chunks, cosmetic tokens	High
Dynamic events	Warehouse fire, flood warning, pickpocket chase, tavern brawl, rat surge	Immediate reward, public participation	Very High
Festival events	Bridge Day, Harvest Fair, Night of Ashes, River Blessing	Titles, cosmetics, recipes, emotes	Seasonal retention

11.1 Reputation Tracks

Faction	Identity	Unlock Examples
Town Watch	Order, defense, legality	Guard-tabard cosmetic, spear techniques, bounty boards
Merchant Compact	Trade and price influence	Listing discounts, market stall permit, trade recipes
Chapel Circle	Faith, records, mercy	Incense recipes, memorial emotes, chapel satchel cosmetic
River Folk	Fishing, cargo, smuggling edge	Boat fares, tackle, hidden stock, river titles
Mudden Kin	Community resilience and hidden routes	Tunnel shortcuts, informal dye set, community aid skills

11.2 Suggested Dynamic Events

- **Market Scuffle:** price gouging sparks a public argument; players can calm, side with, or exploit it.
- **Dock Fire:** lantern accident threatens cargo and nearby homes.
- **Rat Surge:** Mudden Ward asks for help after floodwater drives vermin upward.
- **Bell in the Fog:** a limited-time night event with chapel and underways follow-up.
- **Bridge Inspection:** temporary toll changes and work-order requests for wood, iron, and manpower.
- **Travelers' Fair:** auction fees drop, bard stage opens, food vendors gain festival menus.

12. Social Systems and Service Infrastructure

Good MMO towns earn repeat visits by being useful to communities, not just individuals.

Service / Space	Recommended Location	Purpose	Aesthetic Treatment
Inn bind point	Copper Kettle cluster	Player return anchor	Warm hearth, room keys, copper signage
Bank / storage	Near market but slightly off-center	Shared storage and upgrades	Heavier doors, brass scale motif
Auction house	Market edge	Player trade	Ledger stands, fee board, clerk desks

Service / Space	Recommended Location	Purpose	Aesthetic Treatment
Mail courier	Between market and inn	Messages and parcels	Messenger post with satchel rack
Guild board	Central square or tavern side	Recruitment and social planning	Large wooden board with wax seals
Event board	Fountain / square	Dailies and weeklys	Crier bell, pinned notices
Dueling edge	Outside main square, not in traffic	Player competition without cluttering services	Roped dirt ring or open yard
Festival stage	Market or tavern spillover	Music, speeches, seasonal content	Portable wood dais, lantern stringing

12.1 Optional Long-Term Systems

- **Player housing outskirts:** if housing exists, Harthmere is a strong early-game neighborhood hub.
- **Guild meeting rooms:** rentable upper tavern room or reeve-permitted hall.
- **Marriage / ceremony function:** chapel and market processions support social roleplay systems.
- **Music and performance:** the tavern and square should support bard or emote-heavy social play.
- **Community contribution board:** players donate materials to improve a festival, repair a bridge section, or fund ward relief.

13. Outer Ring Content, Enemy Ecology, and Spawn Logic

The immediate lands beyond Harthmere should teach new players how danger escalates while feeding the town's economy and stories.

Zone	Primary Enemies / Hazards	Town Relationship	Spawn Logic Notes
North Road	Bandits, wolves, broken carts	Protects caravan routes	Low-density beginner combat with visible road safety
South Farms	Boars, crop thieves, stray dogs	Feeds market and inn	Friendly fields with event intrusions, not always hostile
Riverbank	Eels, mud crabs, smugglers, flood pockets	Supports fishing and cargo	Use day/night variation heavily
Woodlot	Wolves, poachers, herb gatherers, hidden ruins	Charcoal and lumber source	Good gathering-and-combat overlap
Graveyard edge	Restless spirits on event nights	Feeds chapel lore	Mostly quiet except specific triggers or festival windows
Underways	Rats, ooze, cult remnants, drowned dead variants	Mystery layer	Instanced or semi-instanced group path works best

13.1 Spawn Design Rules

- Keep the first road from the gate visually safe for at least a short distance.
- Use **soft telegraphing** for danger: broken fences, crows, blood on stones, strange silence, or fog thickness.
- Respawn pacing near town should avoid frustration and preserve roleplay space.
- Rare elite encounters should appear on the outer ring, never in the player-service core.
- Event spawns can temporarily push danger inward, but town guards and public messaging should frame the escalation.

14. UX, Wayfinding, Accessibility, and Readability Rules

A rich town can easily become confusing. This section keeps Harthmere readable.

Need	Rule	Implementation Idea
Finding services	Every major service has one landmark, one icon sign, and one distinct ambient prop cluster	Example: smithy = anvil sign + sparks + horseshoe wall
Route memory	Main roads are wider and cleaner than side lanes	Use street surface contrast and banner lines
District recognition	Each district gets a dominant color family and prop language	Market produce colors vs. chapel calm blues vs. dock ropes and nets
Accessibility	Never depend on color alone for navigation	Combine color with iconography, silhouette, sound, and layout
Controller users	Keep service interactions grouped and visible from approach angles	Reduce narrow hidden door reliance for critical services
Map clarity	The in-game map should label both district names and service icons	North Gate, Market, Craftsman Row, Chapel, Docks, etc.

14.1 New Player Onboarding Prompts

- The first NPC should speak in a way that naturally points to the square, inn, and market notice board.
- Starter UI prompts should appear at service thresholds, not all at once at the gate.
- Use visible civic language: toll, market, chapel, stables, reeve's hall, docks.
- Place one helpful ambient NPC near the fountain who says things like, 'If you need a room, follow the copper kettle sign.'

15. Audio, VFX, Seasonal Variants, and Moment-to-Moment Aesthetic Notes

Area	Audio Emphasis	VFX / Atmosphere	Seasonal Notes
Gate	Chains, hoofbeats, guards, crows	Dust, brazier embers, cold breath	Snow banks in winter, wildflower verge in spring
Market	Vendor calls, animals, fountain, music	Steam, produce flies, event lanterns	Harvest overload in autumn, ribbons in festival season
Craftsman Row	Hammer, saw, bellows, kiln hum	Sparks, steam, sawdust, heat shimmer	More chimney smoke in winter
Inn	Fiddle, chatter, mug clink, fire	Hearth sparks, candle flicker, pipe smoke	Winter crowd density higher
Chapel	Soft bells, prayer, wind, pages	Incense, stained light, drifting wax motes	Memorial flowers in spring; ash candles in winter ritual
Docks	Water slap, gulls, rope creak	Fog, lantern reflections, dripping wood	Storm dressings and blue flood ribbons in spring
Mudden Ward	Dogs, wash tubs, muttering, coughs	Smoke, puddles, laundry movement	More mud in rain season; extra braziers in winter

15.1 Seasonal Town Swaps

- **Spring:** muddy roads, river caution banners, pale flowers, fresh herb stalls.
- **Summer:** brighter market cloth, open windows, busier night social play.

- **Autumn:** apples, harvest bundles, ochre leaves, cider signage, fair decorations.
- **Winter:** smoke, frost, snow on roofs, braziers, thicker cloaks, Night of Ashes event props.

16. MMO Player Storyboard

This keeps the original storyboard spirit but frames it as an MMO experience.

Panel	Player Experience	Visual Beat	Systems Beat
1. Approach	Player sees Harthmere from the road	Bridge silhouette, walls, smoke, morning mist	Safe arrival zone
2. Entry	Gate interaction and town welcome	Guards, toll desk, queue, banners	First dialogue and travel tutorial
3. Reveal	Walk down to market	Fountain, awnings, bustle, service signs	Town orientation and map unlock
4. Utility	Find inn / provisioner / repair	Copper sign, general store clutter, forge sparks	Bind, purchase basics, repair tutorial
5. Choice	Pick a first storyline branch	Chapel calm, reeve's balcony, dock fog, Mudden lane	Branching quest choice
6. Loop	Return after first field content	Warm windows at dusk, town alive again	Sell loot, turn in quests, socialize
7. Deepening	Discover hidden stories and repeats	Bell in fog, dock smuggling, underways entrance	Dailies, reputation, mystery content
8. Belonging	Town becomes home base	Festival market, guild board, familiar NPCs	Long-term retention through social utility

17. Production Checklist and Final Asset List

Use this as a practical handoff list.

Category	Must-Have Assets
Landmarks	North Gate towers, Old Bridge, market fountain, Copper Kettle sign, chapel lantern window, reeve balcony, old well
Service props	Notice boards, auction desk, bank chest, mail post, repair anvil station, stable hitch rails, guild board
Street props	Barrels, crates, sacks, carts, benches, lanterns, buckets, laundry lines, baskets, fences, signs
Craft props	Anvils, bellows, quenching tubs, kilns, spinning frames, hide racks, saw horses, tool walls
Food props	Bread baskets, produce piles, meat hooks, fish racks, mugs, stew pots, pie trays
Atmosphere	Fog cards, chimney smoke, spark emitters, drifting insects, rain ripples, puddles, leaf scatter
NPC kits	Guard kit, merchant kit, laborer kit, noble kit, clergy kit, dock kit, poor ward kit, child kit
Seasonal swaps	Harvest bundles, winter snow caps, spring ribbons, festival lantern strings, memorial flowers

17.1 Final Quality Checklist

- Can a new player find the inn, repair, market board, and crafting zone quickly?
- Does each district read differently at both noon and night?
- Do interactable buildings stand out without breaking immersion?
- Does the town remain useful after the first 10–20 hours of play?
- Are there enough social anchors for players to gather naturally?

- Are economy sinks and profession loops local enough to matter?
- Does the town tell a story even when no quest text is open?
- Do weather, sound, and VFX reinforce the same identity?

18. Final Summary

The expanded Harthmere document now includes the finer details you asked for: stronger color and material direction, more exact aesthetic rules, clearer district identities, MMO service planning, richer social and economy systems, repeatable content structure, and a more production-friendly format.

In short, Harthmere is now positioned not just as a medieval town concept, but as a complete MMO hub bible: something a writer, environment artist, level designer, systems designer, quest designer, UX designer, and producer can all use together.

If you continue building this world, the next most useful follow-up documents would be: **(1)** a top-down map and callout sheet, **(2)** a vendor economy spreadsheet, **(3)** a quest flow chart, and **(4)** a 3D modular asset kit list by district.